PA 103 Regional Integration

Leon N Lindberg Study Guide

Political Integration as a Multidimensional Phenomenon Requiring Multivariate Measurement

Leon N. Lindberg (1970) | *International Organization* 24(4), 648-731

The central argument

Political integration is the evolution of a collective decision-making system among nations. Its properties are interrelated, yet they may change at different rates and in different directions. Researchers need several measures to describe that changing system before explaining it.

The ten properties form a profile of **level, activators, and consequences**. Their relationships over time help explain whether collective decision-making expands, contracts, or stabilizes. Adding ten scores with equal weights would conceal differences unless a theory justified the combination.

About Lindberg

The article identifies Lindberg as a political science professor at the University of Wisconsin-Madison and a member of the Board of Editors of *International Organization*. It also notes his work at Harvard's Center for International Affairs. Here, his contribution is methodological: making political integration observable and comparable.

Guide to the presentation

Slides	Subject
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28-30	Theory context, contribution, limits, and conclusion

Article page references use printed pagination. The three case studies are additional applications of Lindberg's concepts, rather than cases he analyzes in the 1970 article. Numbered references identify their sources.

Slides 2-5

The problem and the definition

Specify what is being explained

Researchers used integration to describe different outcomes: trade, shared identity, peaceful relations, institutions, and political union. If the dependent variable is unclear, explanations can appear to conflict even when they address different phenomena. Lindberg responds by specifying collective political decision-making as the object of analysis (pp. 650-651).

Political integration

His definition concerns the evolution over time of a collective decision-making system among nations (p. 650). The relevant evidence is regularized joint involvement in authoritative public decisions, including the allocation of values and resources. A meeting or treaty may begin this process, but its existence alone does not establish the system's development.

Concept	What it describes	Relation to political integration
Social community	Trust, attachment, and identification among populations.	May support collective authority, but shared identity does not establish joint public decisions.
Security community	Reliable expectations of peaceful dispute settlement.	Peace can coexist with largely autonomous national decision-making.
Economic union	Economic exchange and movement of productive factors.	Economic links can create political demands; trade volume alone does not measure collective authority.
Political integration	An evolving collective decision-making system.	The political process Lindberg directly seeks to measure.

An illustration from customs

The EU customs union is politically relevant because common external tariff rules constrain national tariff choices. Increasing trade is a different observation. To identify political integration, examine who makes the rule, how it applies, and how much national discretion remains. [2]

Cooperation and integration: cooperation can remain occasional and nationally autonomous. Political integration concerns the development of a regular collective process with consequential authority. Its degree must still be measured.

Slides 6-7

The ten properties

The 3-4-3 grouping is a memory aid: three properties of level, four activators, and three consequences. It is not a separate framework named by Lindberg.

Group	Property	Question to ask
Level	1. Functional scope	Which policy areas enter collective decision-making, and how important are they?
Level	2. Range of decision stages	How far does collective activity reach through the decision process?
Level	3. Relative decisiveness	How much weight do collective choices have relative to national choices?
Activators	4. Demand flow	What claims are directed to the collective arena, by whom, and with what strength?
Activators	5. Resources	What institutional, legal, financial, political, and other capacities are available?
Activators	6. Leadership	Who mobilizes those capacities and advances collective action?
Activators	7. Bargaining modalities	How do actors negotiate and handle competing interests?
Consequences	8. Penetrativeness	Whose behavior changes because of collective decisions, and how much?
Consequences	9. Compliance	Are collective decisions accepted, implemented, and observed?
Consequences	10. Distributive consequences	What benefits and costs arise, and who receives or bears them?

Why a profile is necessary

A system may cover many policy areas while national governments retain decisive control. Another may cover few areas but make important collective choices in them. Institutions can remain active even when compliance weakens. These combinations make one indicator insufficient (p. 651).

The properties are parts of one system. Calling them distinct does not mean they operate independently. The purpose of disaggregation is to observe their different patterns and investigate their relationships.

The property grouping is introduced in the article's discussion of the collective decision-making system, pp. 657-659.

Slides 8-11

Level of collective decision making

1 Functional scope

Scope identifies the policy areas handled collectively. Counting areas is insufficient because they differ in salience and political importance (p. 665). Several minor technical programs may coexist with national control over central public choices.

2 Range of decision stages

Lindberg distinguishes **problem-recognition, decision, and application** (pp. 668-671). The six activity labels in the slides unpack these broad stages for teaching. His Figure 4 also contains six ordinal ranks, but those ranks are different:

Rank	Collective involvement in Figure 4
1	Recognition of a common problem and joint information gathering.
2	Definition of specific acceptable action alternatives.
3	Choice of policy guidelines, translated into policy nationally.
4	Detailed collective goal-setting, implemented through national rules.
5	Rules directly binding on individuals, administered and enforced nationally.
6	Collective institutions administer and enforce binding rules.

The scale shows why national administration does not automatically mean that collective authority is weak. National officials can apply binding collective rules. The ASEAN nursing arrangement offers a different division: regional eligibility conditions coexist with national assessment and licensing. [8]

3 Relative decisiveness

Decisiveness concerns the collective arena's weight in the most important choices within an issue area. Lindberg's NATO illustration refers to the 1950s: collective policy guidelines covered few areas but central policy questions (p. 672). Limited scope and a limited stage range can therefore coexist with politically important collective choices.

Slides 12-14

Activators of collective decisions

Activators describe the political activity and capacities that sustain a collective system. Their presence and their actual use are separate observations.

4 Demand flow

Measure the volume, variety, strength, and direction of claims for collective action. Lindberg describes demand as the system's lifeblood (p. 679). A serious regional problem is not itself evidence of demand flow; researchers must trace requests directed to the collective arena.

5 Resources

Resources include agreements, institutions, legal authority, information, money, legitimacy, political support, and experience with compliance. A treaty or committee establishes a capacity, but available funds, staff, and effective authority also require investigation.

6 Leadership

Leadership mobilizes resources by advancing proposals, building support, setting agendas, and brokering agreement. Lindberg describes resources as action potentials that leaders must use (p. 697). A signature records agreement; identifying leadership requires evidence about what actors did to secure it.

7 Bargaining modalities

Bargaining modalities concern how actors negotiate. Competitive bargaining concentrates on separate gains; variable-sum bargaining can seek joint gains through concessions, linked issues, or a broader common interest. An agreement alone does not reveal the exact modality. Conflict within accepted collective procedures can coexist with integration.

A hypothetical haze negotiation

Suppose governments request joint smoke monitoring. The requests illustrate **demand flow**. Staff, funds, and equipment illustrate **resources**. An official who assembles support and brokers a proposal illustrates **leadership**. Negotiations over funding and prevention responsibilities illustrate **bargaining**.

This short example separates four questions about one episode. It does not claim that this particular negotiation occurred. The longer haze case uses documented institutional provisions and identifies the additional records needed to measure political activity.

Slides 15-17

Consequences of collective decisions

8 Penetrativeness

Penetrativeness asks whose behavior changes, how much, and at which social or governmental levels. Effects may reach governments, agencies, firms, groups, or citizens (pp. 709-711). The existence of a rule does not prove the extent of behavioral change.

The agricultural illustration in the reading

Lindberg discusses possible consequences of agricultural decisions, including farmers changing crops or leaving farming (p. 709). These illustrate what a researcher would investigate. They are not proof that a particular collective policy caused farmers to do either.

Attribution is essential. Prices, weather, technology, and national policy can also alter farming. A stronger study compares behavior across time and relevant cases, then examines whether collective decisions contributed to the change.

9 Compliance

Compliance concerns whether collective decisions are accepted, implemented, obeyed, and enforced. Monitoring and enforcement records help test observance. A violation can indicate a compliance problem, but a detected violation can also demonstrate active enforcement. Neither fact alone establishes an overall compliance rate.

10 Distributive consequences

Distribution concerns the benefits and costs collective decisions create and how they are shared. In the agricultural illustration, a study could examine which farmers gain, which bear adjustment costs, and how the effects change political support.

Property	Distinct question
Penetrativeness	Did behavior change because of the collective decision?
Compliance	Were the decision's requirements observed?
Distribution	Who received benefits or bore costs?

Unequal gains do not automatically mean higher or lower integration. Their political effect depends on how recipients and those bearing costs respond in later rounds of collective decision-making.

Slide 18

Feedback and measurement over time

How consequences return to the system

Past collective decisions can reshape later demands, resources, leadership, bargaining, compliance, and the level of collective authority. Lindberg asks which consequences affect which later properties and through what causal processes (p. 725). Integration does not necessarily move in one direction.

Direction	What must change	Hypothetical haze example
Spillover	Past experience contributes to greater integration.	Experience with joint monitoring leads to additional collective fire-prevention tasks.
Spill-back	Past experience contributes to a reduction in integration.	Opposition or implementation problems lead governments to remove collective authority or joint tasks.
Encapsulation	The system stabilizes its existing level while containing pressures.	Governments retain the monitoring arrangement without major expansion or contraction.

These are hypothetical branches. A disappointing outcome is not automatically spill-back, and a successful program is not automatically spillover. Establish what changed in collective decision-making and connect that change to earlier experience.

Feedback is not the same as a direction

A review that informs a later plan documents a feedback process. Classifying its direction requires further evidence. A revised plan may improve procedures while leaving scope, stage range, and decisiveness largely unchanged.

Why an overall score requires theory

Lindberg proposes describing integration through ten ranges of variation (p. 719). He also explores combinations and aggregate measures. His objection is to premature aggregation: weights and relationships cannot be justified by arithmetic convenience alone (pp. 724-725).

Compare profiles at more than one point in time. Preserve differences among issue areas, specify indicators and coding rules, and explain the assumptions behind any combined measure.

Slides 19-20

EU customs union and reform

The customs union began in 1968. This case considers common customs rules and the reform sequence from the Commission's May 2023 proposal to negotiations and approval in 2026. The reform's future implementation must be distinguished from current operational capacity. [2-7]

Property	Application to the case
1. Functional scope	Customs policy covers goods entering the EU and trade among members. It is one issue area with important effects on commerce.
2. Decision stages	Common rules are made collectively; national customs offices apply declarations, checks, and controls. Collective rule-making and national administration coexist.
3. Relative decisiveness	The common external tariff constrains members' discretion to choose separate tariffs for the same imported product and origin.
4. Demand flow	Growth in small parcels and uneven controls prompted calls for reform. Measure demand by tracing actual claims to EU decision-making bodies.
5. Resources	Common law, national offices, and information systems provide capacity. The adopted reform adds a data hub and customs authority, with phased implementation.
6. Leadership	The Commission advanced a proposal in May 2023. The proposal history supports agenda-setting; fuller leadership analysis would trace coalition-building and brokerage.
7. Bargaining modalities	The Council revised the proposal, including provisions for smaller firms. Council-Parliament negotiations produced agreement in March 2026. Negotiating records are needed to classify the bargaining style.

A shipment from the Philippines

Suppose goods enter through the Netherlands and are released into free circulation before moving to Germany. No additional customs duty applies between those member states. Other taxes and product requirements can still apply. This imagined shipment illustrates common rules that constrain national action; it is not a documented transaction. [2]

Slide 21

EU customs consequences and feedback

Property	Evidence and interpretation
8. Penetrativeness	Customs procedures reach importers who submit information and national officials who apply common rules. Measuring behavioral change requires comparison with earlier practice.
9. Compliance	Counterfeit-goods detentions demonstrate enforcement and continuing violations. They do not establish the proportion of all traders or shipments that comply.
10. Distributive consequences	In 2024, 75% of customs duties collected went to the EU budget. That revenue allocation does not establish who ultimately bears tariff or administrative costs.

Interpreting the reform

Problems with the existing system contributed to a reform proposal, amendments, negotiation, and final Council approval in September 2026. The adopted reform adds common instruments, including a customs authority and data hub. This sequence is consistent with possible spillover toward deeper coordination within the issue area. [3-7]

That interpretation remains conditional. Formal approval does not establish that all new capacities are operating or that every property has increased. The Council's timetable schedules the authority's operations for 2027 and later phases for the data hub. [3]

What a fuller study would test

Trace how experience with existing controls entered demands and proposals. Compare collective and national authority before and after implementation. Examine whether the new instruments change data practices, enforcement, compliance, and costs, rather than counting their legal creation alone.

Also consider external pressures. The growth of online trade may generate new demands independently of earlier institutional performance. A causal account should establish how both contributed to reform.

What the case demonstrates

A limited policy scope can contain consequential collective authority. National officials may implement binding common rules. Consequences can generate demands for change, but the direction and extent of integration require observations over time.

Sources: [2-7]; Lindberg, pp. 709-711 and 725. The spillover classification is an application of his concepts, not a finding in the 1970 article.

Slides 22-23

ASEAN recognition of nursing qualifications

ASEAN's Mutual Recognition Arrangement on Nursing Services was signed in Cebu on 8 December 2006. It creates regional conditions and cooperation while leaving professional licensing subject to host-country requirements. [8-9]

Property	Application to the case
1. Functional scope	Recognition of nursing qualifications and professional mobility is a specific issue area within a wider services agenda.
2. Decision stages	Regional agreement establishes eligibility conditions. National nursing regulators assess applications, issue permission to practise, and monitor practice.
3. Relative decisiveness	The regional framework guides recognition, but domestic laws and regulators retain licensing responsibilities. A home-country licence does not automatically authorize host-country practice.
4. Demand flow	Professional mobility is an objective. Measuring demands requires records of claims by nurses, employers, governments, or other actors directed to the collective arena.
5. Resources	National regulators, the joint coordinating committee, expertise, and information exchange provide institutional capacity. Actual staffing, funding, and use need investigation.
6. Leadership	Ministerial signatures document agreement. Identify who proposed provisions, mobilized support, or brokered compromises through the negotiation history.
7. Bargaining modalities	The joint committee can help resolve implementation disputes. Records are needed to show how mobility goals were reconciled with national professional safeguards.

A Philippine nurse applies abroad

Imagine a qualified Philippine nurse seeking work in another participating ASEAN country. The arrangement offers a recognition process, but the applicant must satisfy the receiving country's registration and other requirements. This is an illustrative scenario, not evidence that recognition or migration has occurred. [8]

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Nursing consequences and possible feedback

The following are empirical questions. The arrangement's legal provisions do not establish actual migration, income gains, or health-system staffing effects.

Property	Evidence to investigate
8. Penetrativeness	Do procedures change nurses' applications, qualifications, or work locations? Examine registration and application records and compare them over time.
9. Compliance	Do regulators apply the agreed process and do nurses meet local requirements? Compare actual case handling with the arrangement and domestic rules.
10. Distributive consequences	Who gains employment opportunities, pays recognition or training costs, or bears staffing losses? Examine nurses, employers, and health services in sending and receiving countries.

Possible directions of feedback

Spillover: experience with recognition generates support for additional joint tasks or more authoritative common arrangements. Deeper harmonization could fit this pattern if collective decision-making actually increases.

Spill-back: experience leads governments to remove joint recognition tasks or reduce collective authority. Slow implementation or dissatisfaction alone does not prove this direction.

Encapsulation: governments maintain the existing framework while containing pressures for expansion or withdrawal. Stability must be observed, rather than inferred from the continued existence of the agreement.

The attribution problem

Migration also depends on wages, recruitment, language, immigration rules, and personal choices. More movement after 2006 would not by itself show that the arrangement caused it. Compare the recognition process and relevant alternative explanations.

The case illustrates a division of regional and national authority. It does not rank ASEAN as a whole against the EU. The comparison is limited to particular issue areas and decision stages.

Sources: [8-9]; Lindberg, pp. 709-711 and 725. Outcomes and feedback directions here are questions or hypotheses, not measured findings.

Slides 25-26

ASEAN cooperation on transboundary haze

Severe fires in 1997-1998 preceded the 2002 ASEAN Agreement on Transboundary Haze Pollution. The agreement connects prevention, monitoring, technical cooperation, and coordinated response to haze from land and forest fires. [10-11]

Property	Application to the case
1. Functional scope	The issue area is haze from land and forest fires, including prevention and monitoring. Environmental salience is separate from the amount of collective authority.
2. Decision stages	National monitoring agencies provide information; regional procedures organize reports and coordination. National agencies carry out much prevention and response work.
3. Relative decisiveness	Determine which national choices collective rules actually constrain. Regional coordination does not mean that all domestic decisions have moved to ASEAN bodies.
4. Demand flow	Damaging fire seasons can generate pressure. Trace actual requests for collective action rather than treating fires themselves as political demands.
5. Resources	The agreement, meteorological monitoring, and Haze Fund provide capacities. Available money, technical staff, and effective use require separate measures.
6. Leadership	Environment ministers adopted a second roadmap in 2023, informed by review of earlier implementation. Identify particular agenda-setters and brokers with further evidence.
7. Bargaining modalities	Examine negotiations over responsibilities and costs. An agreement does not alone establish whether actors used concessions, common-interest arguments, or unresolved national positions.

A fire becomes a regional concern

Imagine smoke crossing a border. National monitoring centres exchange regional reports so governments can assess risks and coordinate action. The scenario illustrates national work within a regional framework; it does not describe a particular fire response. [11]

Slide 27

Haze consequences and observed feedback

A July 2024 ministerial release reported roughly three times as many hotspots in the **southern ASEAN subregion** in 2023 as in 2022. It connected the increase to a prolonged dry season and climate conditions, including El Nino. This is a subregional comparison, not a total for all ASEAN. [13]

Property	Evidence to investigate
8. Penetrativeness	Do collective measures change land-clearing, fire-prevention, or local enforcement practices? Separate those changes from weather-driven changes in smoke or hotspot counts.
9. Compliance	Do agencies share required information and implement prevention commitments? Check specific obligations and actions. Recurrent haze alone cannot identify noncompliance or the responsible actor.
10. Distributive consequences	How are cleaner-air and health benefits shared? Who bears prevention, monitoring, and firefighting costs? Examine countries, communities, firms, and land users.

A documented feedback process

Review of the first roadmap's implementation contributed to the second roadmap, adopted in August 2023. Earlier performance therefore informed a later collective plan. That is evidence of a feedback mechanism. [12]

Its direction remains an empirical question. **Spillover** would require wider joint tasks, greater collective stage involvement, or more decisive authority. **Spill-back** would require contraction. **Encapsulation** would involve stabilization of the existing level while pressures are contained.

What the environmental figures can establish

Hotspot counts help describe conditions. They cannot alone establish the agreement's causal effect. Weather, land-use practices, enforcement, and collective action can all matter. A study should trace behavioral and institutional changes as well as environmental outcomes.

The distinction is between a documented review-and-revision process and a demonstrated change in political integration. A revised roadmap is not automatically proof of deeper collective authority.

Sources: [10-13]; Lindberg, pp. 709-711 and 725.

Slides 28-30

Theory context and methodological value

Thinker	Role in the discussion
Ernst Haas	Frames the theoretical and dependent-variable debate, including premature operationalization. Lindberg also warns against premature aggregation.
Joseph Nye	Separates different meanings and measures of integration, an important step toward clearer comparison.
Karl Deutsch	Provides related approaches involving transactions, communication, attitudes, and security community. These do not by themselves measure collective political authority.
Lindberg	Specifies and operationalizes the evolving properties of a collective decision-making system.

Contribution

The article connects an abstract concept to observable properties and possible measurement procedures. It allows comparisons across systems, issue areas, and time without assuming that every dimension changes together. Profiles identify the patterns that causal explanations must address.

Limits

The framework requires substantial data and judgments about salience, behavior, and causation. Lindberg's operational suggestions are tentative and require testing for reliability and validity. Many empirical illustrations draw on European Community experience. Contemporary cases therefore require adaptation and evidence, rather than automatic transfer of scores.

Applying the method

Begin with the political object and the observation period. Define each property, select indicators, collect evidence, and compare profiles. Examine how earlier decisions affect later political activity. Causal theory is necessary to explain those relationships and justify meaningful aggregation.

This sequence reflects the report's emphasis on conceptualization, operationalization, measurement, and application. The EU and ASEAN cases make those methodological choices concrete.

Lindberg (1970), opening conceptual discussion and concluding discussion of aggregation and systems analysis, especially pp. 719-725.

Slides 19-27

Comparing the cases

Dimension	EU customs	ASEAN nursing	ASEAN haze
Issue area	Customs and trade in goods.	Recognition and mobility of nurses.	Haze from land and forest fires.
Collective and national work	Common rules and tariff; national customs administration.	Regional conditions; national assessment and licensing.	Regional monitoring and coordination; national prevention and response.
Consequences to examine	Importer practices, enforcement, revenue, and costs.	Applications, registration, mobility, and staffing effects.	Prevention behavior, obligations, health benefits, and costs.
Feedback evidence	Reform responds to system problems; deeper coordination remains subject to implementation.	Possible directions are hypotheses requiring implementation and decision records.	Implementation review informed a new roadmap; direction requires authority and task comparisons.

Keep the unit of comparison specific

Compare the same property in a defined issue area and period. Different legal arrangements and domestic conditions affect what an observation means. These cases illustrate profiles, not a ranking of entire regional organizations.

Distinctions to remember

Scope, stages, and decisiveness: breadth of policy coverage, reach through the decision process, and weight of collective choices. **Resources and leadership:** available capacity and the work that mobilizes it. **Penetrativeness and compliance:** behavioral effects and observance of requirements.

Description and explanation: a profile identifies what changed; causal theory accounts for why. **Feedback and its direction:** evidence that experience informs later action does not by itself identify spillover, spill-back, or encapsulation.

From an illustration to a study

Define the period and actors. Specify indicators and coding rules. Collect legal provisions, decisions, negotiation histories, budgets, and implementation records. Compare observations across time, assess alternative causes, and explain any weighting used in an aggregate measure.

Review

Questions and answers

What is Lindberg's main argument?

Political integration is an evolving collective decision-making system. Its interrelated properties may change unevenly, so several measures are needed to describe the system and support explanation.

Is 3-4-3 Lindberg's name for the framework?

No. It is a memory aid for his grouping of three level properties, four activators, and three consequences.

Does national implementation mean weak integration?

Not necessarily. National officials can apply binding collective rules. Examine their discretion, the stage involved, and the decisiveness of collective choices.

Why is ASEAN nursing recognition not automatic?

The arrangement establishes regional conditions, but host-country laws and nursing regulators retain assessment and licensing responsibilities. A Philippine licence alone is insufficient.

Does signing an agreement prove leadership and demand flow?

It proves formal agreement. Leadership requires evidence of proposal-making, support-building, or brokerage. Demand flow requires actual claims directed to the collective arena.

Does a new haze roadmap demonstrate spillover?

It documents a response to earlier experience. Spillover requires evidence that collective decision-making increased. A revised plan alone does not establish that change.

What do the customs-revenue and hotspot figures tell us?

The 75% figure concerns the allocation of customs duties collected in 2024, not tariff cost incidence. The hotspot comparison concerns the southern ASEAN subregion and is affected by climate conditions; it is not a stand-alone compliance measure.

Can the ten properties be added into one score?

Only with justified assumptions about weights and relationships. Lindberg explores aggregation but cautions against combining dimensions prematurely.

What would strengthen these case studies?

Evidence over time: actual decisions, negotiating records, resources used, implementation, and behavioral effects. The illustrations identify what to measure; they do not supply complete empirical scores.

References

Numbers identify sources cited in the case discussions. Article page references use printed pagination. Institutional sources were consulted on 5 October 2026.

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